Aeonian Parallax

by Megan Mandana



Aeonian Parallax by Megan Mandana

ISBN: 978-1-61387-120-1

Copyright 2020 by SpeechGeek.

Free performance of this play for high school and college level competitive forensics is permitted. All other rights reserved.

This PDF version of this selection, e-published in 2020, is identical to the printed published version of this same publication dated 2020. This statement along with the entire printed PDF of this publication must be presented at any National Speech and Debate Association District or National event for the script to comply with NSDA rules per the request of the Executive Director.

This and other selections of quality performance literature for competitive oral interpretation are published by SpeechGeek.

For more information and performance rights, contact **SpeechGeek.**

SpeechGeek
248 Arlington Park Dr.
Hot Springs, AR 71901

Phone: 1-888-742-2028
Email: thegeek@speechgeek.com
Web: www.speechgeek.com
Facebook: www.facebook.com/speechgeek

Performance notes: The Overseer may be played by one or both actors. The use of music is permitted to create atmosphere, violin, and transition.

OVERSEER. The Cooperative: society perfected. When our primitive ancestors ruled the world, they made war, famine, crime, and selfishness. But from the ashes of governments and grief rose the Cooperative! Members are provided healthcare, education, employment, purpose, and belonging. At the age of sixteen initiates earn their membership by performing a single act of allegiance, sacrifice, and selflessness. The Cooperative: the future is waiting to welcome you.

NOVA. Excuse me… Astrid?
ASTRID. Nova! (*they embrace as old friends*)
NOVA. What are you doing here? Is it time for you already?
ASTRID. Yes, six months to the day your junior. My birthday is--
NOVA. Next week! Of course, it is. How could I forget?
ASTRID. That's alright. It's wonderful to see you. All of this. It's wonderful.
NOVA. I suppose.
ASTRID. Wait, why are you still here? You haven't earned your membership yet?
NOVA. I'm still preparing.

Whether it's today's world or an AI-controlled futuristic dystopia, the challenges of balancing community and individuality are immense. Playwright Megan Mandana uses the alien landscape of sci-fi to cross-examine the very real struggle of growing up: what is the cost of belonging? What is the value of selfishness?

NOVA. (*Nova picks up her violin again and a small smile appears as she plays.*)
ASTRID. (*enters*) Nova! I have wonderful news. I spoke with the Overseer. They will allow you to be my mentor.
NOVA. Me? There must be a mistake, Mentors are Cooperative members. They've already completed the Sacrifice.
ASTRID. Yes, the Overseer agreed that our Sacrifice can happen simultaneously. They will allow me to complete my choice early to be with you.
NOVA. Ha, "choice."
ASTRID. They… they said your preparations were longer than expected. I told them that you were waiting for me. For this (*a bracelet or memento they share*). Because we always do things together.
NOVA. Astrid. What do you know about the Sacrifice?
ASTRID. Oh, that's easy! It's at the age of sixteen. Initiates earn their membership by performing an act of selflessness. An elective surgery to demonstrate allegiance to the Cooperative.
NOVA. Correct. The surgery was developed as a rite of passage, whereby each initiate sacrifices a part of their primitive self.
ASTRID. Which part?

NOVA. Each initiate is different. The surgery will remove what you love most, in order to prove that you love the Cooperative more.

ASTRID. That's the selflessness part.

NOVA. Yes.

ASTRID. How do they know what I love most?

NOVA. The assessment will test your body and mind to determine your unique profile. Then they prepare you to make your final choice: "Do you wish to join the Cooperative?"

ASTRID. Yes!

NOVA. You don't have to answer yet, Astrid.

ASTRID. Oh, right. Just excited, I guess. …Mentor.

(Transition: Astrid is put into an assessment chamber. She stands arms spread while the chamber reads her and there are sounds, lights, etc.)

OVERSEER. Assessment commencing. The Cooperative: society perfected. 10% complete. Members are provided healthcare, education, employment, purpose, and belonging. 30% complete. At the age of sixteen, initiates earn their membership by performing a single act of allegiance – 50% complete – sacrifice – 65% complete – selflessness – 80% complete. The Cooperative: the future is waiting to welcome you. Assessment complete.

ASTRID. Well? What did the assessment reveal? What is my Sacrifice supposed to be?

NOVA. Astrid, calm down. Your results aren't ready yet.

ASTRID. Is it silly that I hope they change my nose?

NOVA. They take what you love, Astrid. It's not plastic surgery.

ASTRID. But you get it back, right? I mean they replace it.

NOVA. The Sacrifice is replaced with the finest technology, your communication uplink, your finances, your healthcare records, and security measures. Your sacrifice will be linked to your identity. Therefore, if you are offline for too long, the Cooperative will assist to ensure you stay connected.

ASTRID. That's convenient. Nova…what were your assessment results?

NOVA. My…my arm.

ASTRID. What you love most? You loved your arm the most?

NOVA. Not exactly. I love playing the violin.

ASTRID. You won't play anymore?

NOVA. I'll be able to execute any song I choose with my new arm. But I won't feel the strings, or the warm wood against my palm, I won't feel the vibration, but I can play any song I want.

ASTRID. So…what are you waiting for?

NOVA. Astrid, it's complicated.

ASTRID. Nova, it's not complicated. When we were Littles, we used to talk about this day. Joining the Cooperative. Going to school to become teachers or doctors. Having our own Littles.

NOVA. I know.

ASTRID. So make the choice.

NOVA. Choice? What choice, Astrid? Either they are going to take my arm or I'm electing to go to live…where? The outlands? Like the primitives!? That isn't a choice!

ASTRID. Just because you don't like the options, does not mean there is no choice.

NOVA. You sound just like the Overseer.

ASTRID. If you choose yourself, then you choose to be alone.

NOVA. Astrid, I'm not selfish, but I am scared.

ASTRID. Don't think about yourself. Do it for me, Nova. For us. (*references memento again*)

NOVA. …Okay.

OVERSEER. Nova A. Equis do you wish to join the Cooperative?

NOVA. Yes.

ASTRID. Nova. You did it! You completed the Sacrifice. You're part of the Cooperative now.

NOVA. Thank you, Astrid. I'm very tired. Could I ask you to…

ASTRID. Yes, of course. Good night.

(Transition: Astrid leaves. Nova sits down and lets her arm rest lifeless at her side. She looks at it for a moment and then removes it again. She sets it down and massages her arm. She takes a deep breath and closes her eyes and hums softly as she "plays" the violin again without the arm. She enjoys it for a moment, humming softly as if she hears the music in her head. Astrid enters again with a question but catches Nova dreaming and playing.)

NOVA. Astrid! *(quickly grabs and replaces her mechanical arm)*

ASTRID. I thought you said you could still play.

NOVA. Why are you here?

ASTRID. Why did you take the arm off if you can still play?

NOVA. You said good night!

ASTRID. Can't you play anymore?

NOVA. No. I mean, yes. Technically, the music will sound flawless. But when I play now, it won't sound like me.

ASTRID. …So you didn't really get it back at all.

NOVA. It's not much of a Sacrifice if they gave it right back.

ASTRID. That's why you took so long to prepare? Because you knew…

NOVA. **…**I suspected.

ASTRID. Why wouldn't you tell me that? Why wouldn't you tell me that you would regret it?!

NOVA. You told me not to think about myself. You told me to do it for you – for us.

ASTRID. Well none of that even matters now!

NOVA. What?

ASTRID. I got my assessment results. And it's you.

NOVA. What?

ASTRID. My Sacrifice to join the Cooperative is my love for you.

NOVA. How would they even…?

ASTRID. I won't remember you. I won't remember this. (*holds up the memento*)

NOVA. You lose us so you can be part of the Collective?! What kind of a choice is that?

ASTRID. Just because I don't like the options does not mean there is no choice.

NOVA. To hell with this! (*removes her arm quickly and smashes it on the ground*)

ASTRID. The security measures!

NOVA. Astrid, every choice has a consequence, and you have to decide what it is worth to you.

ASTRID. What are you doing?

NOVA. I am your Mentor, remember? This is me preparing you! You don't have to do this.

ASTRID. But what about—

NOVA. You choose, Astrid! Don't do this for me. Don't do this for them. Do what is right for you. Astrid!? (*she is dragged away*)

ASTRID. Nova!

OVERSEER. Astrid J. Davis. Do you wish to belong to the Cooperative?

ASTRID. I…don't know. I'm scared.

OVERSEER. Astrid J. Davis. You must make your choice.

ASTRID. Healthcare, education, employment… I've wanted this since I was a little. But what good is it without Nova?

OVERSEER. Astrid J. Davis. Do you wish to belong to the Cooperative?

ASTRID. I don't want to be alone!

OVERSEER. Astrid J. Davis. Your choice is made.

(Transition: Astrid enters. Nova is there, she sees her and approaches cautiously)

NOVA. Astrid?

ASTRID. **…**Yes?

END